

Inspection of West Northamptonshire local authority children's services

Inspection dates: 11 to 22 May 2026

Lead inspector: Rebecca Dubbins, His Majesty's Inspector

Judgement	Grade
The impact of leaders on social work practice with children and families	Outstanding
The experiences and progress of children who need help and protection	Good
The experiences and progress of children in care	Good
The experiences and progress of care leavers	Good

Services for children and families in West Northamptonshire have significantly improved since the last inspection in 2022, when the overall effectiveness judgement was 'requires improvement to be good'. Children's social care and targeted early help services are delivered by Northamptonshire Children's Trust (NCT), which has been in existence since 1 November 2020. Shortly after NCT's inception, on 1 April 2021, Northamptonshire Council split into West and North Northamptonshire councils. Some services continue to be delivered jointly between the two local authorities.

Leaders in West Northamptonshire have ensured that children and their families now receive good services. Leaders have a thorough understanding of the needs of children and families in their area and have strengthened and developed relationships with leaders in NCT, North Northamptonshire and with partners. As a result, leaders have invested and developed services that have made a difference for children and their families. Leaders inspire their workforce to do their very best, and this was evident in the practice seen. Children spoke positively about the support they receive and how their workers are ambitious for them. Exemplary leadership has created a highly positive workplace culture and has set the standards for workers and managers, always with children at the heart of what they do. Leaders have enabled a previously fragmented and temporary workforce to become stable and skilled, so that children and families have a consistent experience. Workers

demonstrate high aspirations for children, developing positive relationships, to help and support them to make necessary changes.

What needs to improve?¹

- The quality of the support and plans for children in need, including disabled children. (Outcome 1, national framework)
- Communication of the local offer for care-experienced young adults, including clarity about the support provided to those over the age of 21. (Outcome 4, national framework)

The experiences and progress of children who need help and protection: good

1. Children and their families receive good and effective help and support, benefiting from a wide and increasing range of early help services to avoid the need for statutory intervention. When these services are not improving children's lives, or when risks emerge, early help practitioners appropriately escalate their concerns to the multi-agency safeguarding hub (MASH).
2. Children and families referred to the MASH receive timely and effective responses from skilled and curious workers who understand risk. They liaise with partners to ensure that appropriate information is shared to consider next steps. Partners have revised the threshold document together, and multi-agency training has been delivered. As a result, thresholds are well understood. Robust management oversight at key decision-making points provides rationale and clear direction as to the next steps required to safeguard and/or support children.
3. When children require help and protection out of office hours, they receive an effective and responsive service from the emergency duty team. This service has been strengthened since the last inspection, and has separated from adult services, so the focus is solely on the needs of children and their families.
4. Culturally competent social workers, using a relational and systemic approach, are skilled at building trusting relationships with children, their families and their wider family network. This helps them to develop a sound understanding of what life is like for individual children. As a result, assessments are comprehensive, taking into consideration both historical and emerging concerns. A small and reducing number of children have not benefited from consistent social workers over time, which has impacted on the quality of intervention for these children.

¹ The areas for improvement have been cross-referenced with the outcomes, enablers or principles in the [Children's Social Care: National Framework](#). This statutory guidance sets out the purpose, principles for practice and expected outcomes of children's social care.

5. When there are concerns for a child's safety, promptly convened strategy meetings, attended by the right professionals, ensure that relevant information is shared. This enables effective and proportionate multi-agency decision-making, which is in children's best interests. Child protection investigations are thorough and explore strengths and risks, and consider the views of key professionals, children, both their parents and extended family members. Safety plans are put in place at the earliest opportunity to ensure that any risks are managed.
6. Initial child protection conferences result in effective multi-agency plans that reduce risks for children. Advocates attending conferences with or on behalf of children ensure that children's views inform planning. Social workers are proactive to understand the views of both parents, even when a non-resident parent may be reluctant to contribute. Family network meetings are routinely undertaken to explore how the child's informal support network can contribute to the plan, thus maximising support for children.
7. Children subject to child protection and children in need plans benefit from effective multidisciplinary interventions to address underlying issues that are affecting children's experiences. Interventions are purposeful, and include robust safety planning to help families to achieve sustainable change. Social work practice in relation to neglect has been strengthened through the well-embedded and dynamic use of a neglect assessment tool. This helps families to understand changes over time and decisions made as a result. There remain, however, a small number of children who have been the subject of lengthy child protection plans as a result of neglect, and changes made not being sustained over time. Managers have effective oversight so that they understand the lived experience of these children, balancing the complex issues very well, taking proportionate and, at times, decisive action when required.
8. The response to domestic abuse is effective, with coordinated support in place to oversee the interventions provided to both parents and to children. This means that parents can understand the impact of domestic abuse on the development and wellbeing of their children, to enable them to make positive changes or take decisive action to manage and reduce any risks.
9. Children's child protection plans are child centred and focus on achieving positive change through coordinated multi-agency and family involvement. The plans are clear about who is doing what and by when to improve children's experiences. However, the quality and monitoring of child in need plans is more variable, including for disabled children and children who are the subject of supervision orders and those who have recently stopped needing a child protection plan. Some of these plans do not always include regular updates or timebound actions. As a result, the intervention and long-term goals for families are less clear and make it difficult to monitor progress effectively for children.

10. When children's experiences do not improve, or when risks escalate, most children are appropriately entered into the pre-proceedings stage of the Public Law Outline in a timely way to give parents a final chance to achieve change. Pre-proceedings letters are not always focused and clear about what needs to change, which can lead to parents being uncertain about the expectations placed on them. More recently, before inspection, these letters were amended to address this uncertainty. Mostly, pre-proceedings processes have had a positive impact for many families, with the need for court proceedings avoided because children's experiences and safety have improved.
11. Specialist interventions and assessments support families to make necessary changes. The family drug and alcohol court (FDAC) and the specialist edge of care services have made an impact, with positive outcomes seen for families. As a result, more children have remained with or have been reunited with their parents.
12. The quality and impact of help and support for disabled children are inconsistent, as assessments and plans do not always consider the wider family context or the roles of other household members. Direct work is not always undertaken with children to understand their wishes and feelings. This misses the opportunity to sufficiently explore and improve relationships in the family home.
13. Children who go missing or who are at risk of exploitation benefit from an effective multi-agency response. The creation of the multi-agency exploitation hub since the previous inspection, and increase in resources to support children who go missing, have had a very positive impact on children's experiences. Children build meaningful relationships with specialist workers, who frequently update risk assessments and plans in line with changing circumstances, harm and threats. This comprehensive response helps to reduce risks to children and disrupt the activities of perpetrators.
14. The local authority designated officer service is mostly effective. However, there is not always a full exploration of potential risks for the children of alleged perpetrators, meaning that any harm these children may have experienced is not always understood.
15. A small number of children have been identified as living in private fostering arrangements in West Northamptonshire. Work is ongoing to raise awareness among partners. However, when these arrangements are known, assessments are thorough and children and their carers are supported effectively.
16. When children aged 16 or 17 present as homeless, they are supported to understand their rights and options. Children who come into care and those who choose to be supported as a child in need are provided with appropriate accommodation and support to help keep them safe and have their needs met.

17. A relatively high number of young carers have been identified in West Northamptonshire, and are supported effectively. A dedicated service has increased the opportunities for social time, and support from a trusted adult has promoted children's resilience and emotional wellbeing. Practitioners from this service regularly attend multidisciplinary meetings when children are subject to child protection and child in need plans. This means that children's needs as young carers are incorporated into plans and interventions to improve their experiences.
18. The local authority maintains clear oversight of children missing education and those who are electively home educated. Staff carry out appropriate checks to ensure that arrangements for vulnerable children are suitable. However, risk assessments do not always sufficiently focus on children with special educational needs and/or disabilities.

The experiences and progress of children in care: good

19. The routine exploration of family networks from an early stage ensures that children can remain living with their families when it is safe for them to do so. For those children who need to come into care, the decision-making is explained well, with their views considered. Mostly, decisions for children to become looked after are planned, appropriate and timely.
20. Reunification is routinely considered when family circumstances change. Children who return to the care of their parents do so as a result of thorough assessment and planning processes. Intervention and support from in-house and external services enable children's parents to make necessary changes. Strong management oversight is in place to ensure that potential risks are managed, and children get the care they need.
21. Most children are living in appropriate homes where they are thriving. They receive good levels of support, whether they live in or out of the area. Children in care benefit from regular, meaningful time with family members, which is supported by robust safety planning. Taking photos to capture family time contributes to ongoing life-story work and strengthens children's identity.
22. For a small minority of children with complex needs, lack of placement choice has meant that they have experienced changes before the right home is found for them. For children not yet living in their long-term home, their current needs are met well and purposeful plans with robust oversight are in place to consider alternative options. These plans carefully balance children's current needs with what they may need in the future, to avoid jeopardising any progress children have made.
23. There has been an ongoing reduction in the use of unregistered children's homes, positively reflecting the impact of leaders' sufficiency planning. When such homes are used for children, this is only when other options have been

fully explored and exhausted, and for the shortest time possible. Children's needs for ongoing education, and regular and meaningful contact with their family, are important considerations in decision-making processes. The chief executive of NCT and the director of children's services (DCS) are fully aware of the circumstances of these children, and ensure that necessary steps are taken to assure themselves that children are safe and their needs are met. Proactive steps are taken by leaders to encourage providers to register and leaders hold weekly meetings to progress this, along with ongoing placement searches. Commissioned visits from an independent person take place and quality assurance processes are followed. This gives leaders an additional perspective and insight. This additional scrutiny, alongside regular social worker and independent reviewing officer (IRO) visits, ensures that children's safety and wellbeing are prioritised and that their day-to-day experiences are understood.

24. Social workers undertake good-quality 'circle to success' assessments. These provide a thorough insight into children's lives and needs, which informs interventions and optimises the placement matching process so that most children do not experience instability. Social work assessments are updated in line with children's changing needs, ensuring that they remain purposeful and meaningful for children.
25. Most children in care are provided with long-term security. Senior managers have effective oversight of permanence, with children living in long-term homes being ratified in a timely way. Kinship carers report positive support, and this has contributed to children's stability. Recent policy changes about special guardianship support are positively influencing carers to opt to pursue this alternative route to care, providing children with permanence and security in line with their wishes.
26. Children, including those in custody, are visited regularly by their social workers, in line with their needs. Children benefit from additional relationships, such as with family support workers and independent visitors. These relationships enhance children's sense of stability and wellbeing.
27. Direct work with children in care is a strength, including for disabled children. Social workers use a vast range of age-appropriate tools, and life-story work is effective in helping children understand their experiences. The circle to success team provides a particularly strong therapeutic offer, characterised by creative, tailor-made interventions and effective multi-agency collaboration. This strengthens children's identity, improves their emotional wellbeing and resilience and has prevented placement disruption.
28. Children's care plans are reviewed in children in care review meetings and progress is monitored through regular monthly meetings. These are well attended, with strong multi-agency engagement. Children's views are well articulated and captured. The minutes reflect children's needs and include a child-focused summary, which celebrates children's achievements and outlines

the plans and support in place. IROs maintain a strong presence between reviews, providing oversight and visits and ensuring that plans progress appropriately.

29. Most children's educational needs are met effectively and they progress well. Regular personal education plans and multidisciplinary meetings ensure a consistent focus on educational progress. Children receive appropriate support to achieve their potential. Access to wider activities further enhances children's enjoyment and development. Many schools and providers benefit from the virtual school's high-quality training, which strengthens support for children in care.
30. While children's health needs are generally well understood and met, there are delays in completing initial and review health assessments. The backlog is reducing, supported by partnership oversight and leadership challenge, with priority allocation considered. Social workers have facilitated access to health services and escalated matters when needed to ensure that this has not had a detrimental impact on children.
31. Unaccompanied asylum-seeking children are referred to as 'separated migrant children' in West Northamptonshire. These children receive sensitive and individualised support. Life-story workbooks, available in both digital and hard copy formats, help these children maintain their connections to their family and culture. Visits are recorded in detail and include consideration of health and education needs and children's immigration status. Social workers understand the journeys children have made in travelling to the UK, and they act to ensure that children can maintain contact with loved ones who live far away.
32. Children in care who go missing or are at risk of exploitation receive coordinated multi-agency support. Safety plans are in place, and social workers remain persistent in engaging children. Responses to missing episodes are effective in identifying underlying causes and inform future planning. Where risks remain high, social workers take appropriate action to reduce risks.
33. Children enjoy participating in the Children in Care Council. Children have helped to design events such as 'The big conversation' so that a wider range of children's views can be sought. This has led to explicit standards for how children wish to be treated and a 'coming into care guide' was co-produced as a result.
34. The fostering service provides appropriate child-centred training and support for carers, and practice has improved. The quality of assessments and written records is a recognised area for development.
35. Adoption practice is strong. The service demonstrates a clear commitment to improvement, relationship-based practice and positive outcomes for adoptive families. As a result of collaborative and effective relationships between the

regional adoption agency (Family Adoption Links) and NCT, children are placed at the right time, in adoptive homes that meet their needs.

The experiences and progress of care leavers: good

36. Care leavers, who are known as 'care-experienced young adults' in West Northamptonshire, receive a good service from their personal advisers (PAs), who are allocated before they reach the age of 18. This helps care-experienced young adults to develop meaningful relationships with their PAs, who assist them to prepare for adulthood.
37. For disabled care-experienced young adults, the planning starts early and PAs and social workers from adult services are allocated in good time for assessments to be undertaken. This gives care-experienced young adults with complex needs assurance about their future living arrangements and plans.
38. PAs know their care-experienced young adults well and understand their day-to-day experiences. PAs visit them regularly in their homes and see them when they drop in at the care leavers hub. Care-experienced young adults spoke positively about the support they receive from their PAs to help them prepare for adulthood, access services and understand their entitlements. They described feeling valued, listened to and encouraged. These views were reflected in care-experienced young adults' written records, which also showed PAs being ambitious for their young people, with clear short-term and long-term goals outlined.
39. The quality of written pathway plans varies. Most pathway plans accurately reflect young people's experiences, strengths and needs and capture their views. They are focused on outlining future plans and support needed. Sometimes however, pathway plans are not sufficiently specific, are not updated and are not always completed collaboratively with young people, which impacts the value of these plans.
40. The care leaver hubs are valued greatly by care-experienced young adults, who access the facilities regularly. There are impressive resources, leisure activities and groups on offer, which aim to expand and develop young people's knowledge, experience and skills. The West Northamptonshire hub is a lovely, welcoming space where the achievements of care-experienced young adults are celebrated with numerous pictures on the walls. Birthday parties are held at the hub and young people described these as a celebration of their lives. Care-experienced young adults continue to use the hubs beyond the age of 25, when they no longer have a PA. The importance of the hub was highlighted by many young adults with care experience, who described the atmosphere in the hub as 'being like one big family' that gives them a sense of belonging.
41. Care-experienced young adults are actively supported to access physical, emotional and mental health services. An in-house mental health practitioner provides support when required, and young people spoke positively about this,

valuing the consistency and responsiveness of support. Although access to wider mental health services remains inconsistent, PAs help care-experienced young adults to navigate services as needed. The hub also provides an opportunity for an informal support network for those with care experience. This has helped them to be open about their difficulties and their worries.

42. Care-experienced young adults are encouraged and supported effectively to remain in education, employment or training. There is regular multi-agency oversight of young people who are not in any form of education, employment or training, with options pursued by PAs. Care-experienced young adults value the support and guidance delivered from the hub, and targeted programmes designed to improve independence and employability.
43. Most care-experienced young adults live in homes where they feel safe and settled. They are encouraged and supported to remain living with their foster carers where possible. They are helped to develop independent living skills regardless of where they live. The staying close project supports those more vulnerable care-experienced young adults to develop skills which will help them to manage and sustain their tenancies. The cohort has increased since its inception in November 2023, and additional properties available now provide more choice. Care-experienced young adults described this project as invaluable, helping them to focus on other areas of their lives, as they are living in a stable environment where they feel safe.
44. Most care-experienced young adults are aware of the local offer and understand how to access support. The offer is broad, provides practical assistance and has a positive impact. However, the communication of this lacked clarity, particularly around financial entitlements. Leaders acknowledged this issue and addressed this immediately.
45. Care-experienced young adults who are expectant parents are supported to access services and to make the necessary preparations for the arrival of their baby. When there are concerns about the care they may provide, these are appropriately shared with the MASH, and PAs support care leavers, together with social work colleagues. When care-experienced young adults are parents, they receive coordinated support from a range of professionals, which helps them to care for their children well.
46. Former separated migrant children are supported effectively to settle into life in the UK through practical, legal and emotional support, which provides security for their future. PAs understand their young people's identity, cultural and religious needs. However, written plans do not consistently reflect these.
47. Care-experienced young adults in custody are supported effectively during their time in prison and in preparation for their release. The beyond custody framework promotes support for care leavers beyond the age of 25 if they want this. This ensures that they receive help at a critical time on their release into the community, regardless of their age. Care-experienced young adults' views,

wishes and feelings are considered. This ensures the right plans are developed with them, leading to better engagement overall, which is likely to positively impact their future plans.

48. When there are concerns about a care-experienced young adult being at risk of exploitation, PAs are relied on to identify risks and seek appropriate support, which they do well. Leaders are already working to strengthen contextual safeguarding arrangements up to the age of 25, in partnership with adult services and the adult safeguarding partnership board.
49. Care-experienced young adults over the age of 21 with particular vulnerabilities, including those with disabilities, those in custody and those who are parents, receive focused and consistent support beyond their 21st birthday. However, for other care-experienced young adults, the communication about ongoing support, and if they can continue to work with their PAs after the age of 21 is not always clear. Some care-experienced young adults over the age of 21 receive effective support through the duty service or from previous PAs who are no longer formally allocated. The lack of clarity is recognised by leaders and there is a clear strategic commitment to improving the consistency of support for this cohort.

The impact of leaders on social work practice with children and families: outstanding

50. A highly effective and strong leadership team has enabled significant improvements to services for children and their families. Since the appointment of the current DCS, who is highly regarded by the chief executives of both the local authority and NCT, improvements have been made at pace. Relationships between leaders in the local authority, in North Northamptonshire and in NCT, have strengthened and this has been a significant catalyst for change. As a result of this collaborative partnership, leaders and elected members in the local authority have a comprehensive and accurate understanding of the needs of children and families in West Northamptonshire, and how well services are meeting their needs.
51. The DCS and the chief executive of NCT are inspirational and determined leaders who are focused on developing practice and improving the lives of children and families. Consequently, the leadership team, both within the local authority and NCT, is aligned on short-term and long-term goals, with a shared vision to improve children's outcomes.
52. A comprehensive and coherent improvement plan, focused on the impact for children, is driving the changes needed. The expectations of leaders are communicated effectively, in well-written policies, practice guidance and regular training events. Practice has improved as a result, for example the work undertaken around neglect is a strength, with assessment tools routinely and dynamically used. The improvement board is well attended and effective,

demonstrating the commitment of senior leaders and partners to improve services in West Northamptonshire.

53. The chief executive of the local authority, leader of the council and lead member are highly engaged in the improvement plan, providing necessary challenge when needed. Children are a priority for the council and all departments work together effectively so improvements can be made. Despite financial challenges, significant investment has been provided to meet demands, with children's services protected from efficiency savings so that improvements can continue. As a result of this investment, services have been developed that have been transformational. Examples include the family hubs, circle to success concept and team, the exploitation hub and staying close team. All of these have made a significant difference to the lives of children, their families and care-experienced young adults.
54. Leaders demonstrate exemplary leadership, showing the workforce how good practice can make a difference to the lives of children and families. Throughout the inspection, the leadership team demonstrated a commitment to continuous learning to improve practice further.
55. Leaders are highly effective corporate parents and understand what children and care leavers need. They are visible, accessible and ambitious for children, and they have ensured that children's voices are sought and heard through participation groups and through the reverse corporate parenting board, where children lead and chair meetings. There is demonstrable evidence that children's voices influence policy and practice and improve communication.
56. Children's achievements are celebrated by their corporate parents at annual events, which are fun filled and child centred. Children told us how important this is for them. Children and care-experienced young adults frequently told us how much they appreciate the chief executive of NCT and described their unique interactions with him, demonstrating a personal and individual connection, but mostly demonstrating how much their successes are celebrated.
57. The care-experienced young adults' offer is improved and more accessible. The offer is balanced to ensure that children who leave care are not disadvantaged and have corporate support from other council departments to improve their lives. Leaders are committed to supporting care-experienced young adults to pursue their potential and have created the care-experienced pledge with local businesses. This has provided numerous employment and support opportunities for their care-experienced young adults. Additionally, the local authority directly employs a number of care experienced apprentices, who are also used to shape services.
58. Strategic partnerships have significantly improved and are now mature. Multi-agency audits have provided appropriate scrutiny of key themes and, as a result of effective partnership work, improvements in practice have been

evidenced. Professional debate and challenge are encouraged and escalations are effective to resolve any issues. Partners collectively ensure that children and their families receive a proportionate and suitable response. Multi-agency partnerships have focused on a preventative agenda, which has ensured an effective response to the most vulnerable children.

59. Leaders understand their sufficiency issues well, and this is set out in a strategy that is informed by a sophisticated and comprehensive needs analysis. Considerable work has been undertaken with significant financial investment and effective joint commissioning arrangements, which has increased capacity and provided more local homes for children in care and care-experienced young adults. The financial package for foster carers has been reviewed and strengthened, with payments reflecting children's needs, comprehensively captured by circle to success assessments. An increasing number of in-house foster carers are now being used.
60. There are a reducing number of children living in unregistered children's homes. Leaders have taken a systematic and robust approach to address placement sufficiency and to oversee individual children's experiences, progress and safety. As a result, more registered children's homes have been created through capital investment, targeted commissioning arrangements and external providers registering their homes.
61. The quality assurance framework is comprehensive and robust and allows senior leaders to have a line of sight to the quality of practice and children's experiences. While further work is needed on case file audits, this is one aspect of an otherwise effective quality assurance framework, which helps leaders to understand gaps and to ensure that practice improves. Inspectors saw many examples of the work undertaken and the positive impact on practice as a result. Improved use of data and performance information has increased leaders' understanding of the impact of practice on children. Existing data is regularly used to test and probe services, giving an accurate picture to provide assurance about the difference made for children and families.
62. As a result of this effective quality assurance programme, leaders are aware of the strengths in their services and the priorities and challenges that remain.
63. Leaders have a clear plan in place to manage the changes needed as a result of the social care reforms. This has been well considered, and governance arrangements are in place to oversee developments, with multi-agency groups already established to deliver the plan and drive the changes required. The positive work undertaken with families provides a strong foundation for these changes.
64. Management oversight from managers at all tiers is reflected in children's records. Supervision is regular, although greater consistency in quality is required. Leaders continue to address this as an area of focus. Inspectors did see reflective supervisions and better-quality discussions in relation to some of

the most vulnerable children, with viable plans in place that were progressing well.

65. Workforce capacity has significantly improved since the last inspection. The NCT and the local authority have a comprehensive workforce development strategy. This includes growing their own staff and recruitment initiatives. As a result of this development, the majority of workers are now permanent, with a greatly reduced number of agency workers being used. Consequently, staff turnover has significantly reduced. Substantial and positive changes in culture have enabled staff retention and attracted people to work for NCT, including those who were previously employed by an agency.
66. Workers benefit from an extensive training and career development offer which supports workforce stability. Managers also benefit from training to develop their knowledge and leadership skills. Newly qualified workers (ASYEs) and those recruited from overseas benefit from a very structured programme, supported by the academy, to ensure they can develop at a pace that is right for them, with wraparound support in place. All workers we spoke to stated they loved working for NCT. Workers were unanimous in their praise for their managers and leaders, stating that they felt supported, equipped and safe, with leaders creating a positive environment, which encourages them to continually improve their practice.

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